Party Strategy or Self-Selection? Examining the Role of Riding Demographics and Co-Ethnic Candidates on Electoral Outcomes for Minorities in Canada

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Introduction

Throughout the past few decades, numerous scholars have attempted to uncover the drivers of lower involvement in politics by racialized Canadians. This analysis finds that racialized Canadians are less represented in the House of Commons than white Canadians, and seeks to explain what factors may affect this lower participation. While important to note that there are less racialized candidates than white candidates overall, racialized candidates win at a lower rate compared to white candidates. This paper aims to examine whether the demographics of a federal electoral district in Canada influence the success rate of racialized candidates. An article by Lublin et al. (2019) found that in the US context, the electoral success of African-American and Latino candidates was influenced by the minority population share, as well as the Republican-voting population share. While there is evidence that other factors, such as partisan divides and American history of racial exclusion may impact racialized candidates' ability to win elections, pursuing this research in the Canadian context is important in determining whether low minority representation stems from district demographics, or is more complex (Black and Erickson 2006, 544).

The secondary goal of this paper is to test the findings of Ie et al. (2025). They found that racialized candidates preferred to run in districts with a greater number of racialized candidates of the same background. To test whether this in-group role model effect (Elections Canada) holds true and whether the number of racialized candidates grows gradually as candidate representation grows, this paper examines the numbers of racialized candidates over time, by districts. Ultimately, this paper finds evidence that minority candidates do receive higher vote shares in minority-dense ridings, while also finding evidence against candidates encouraging more co-ethnic candidates in the next election.

Theory and Hypothesis

The first hypothesis is that a larger minority population share in an electoral district will lead to higher electoral success (greater shares of minority winners and greater vote shares). This is based on research by Tolley (2019), who finds that in highly racialized ridings, there tend to be racialized local party presidents, who are then associated with more racialized candidates emerging in elections. This paper seeks, therefore, to explore whether the candidates that emerge in high-minority ridings have different levels of electoral success compared to their non-minority counterparts. It may be possible that minority-rich ridings experience affinity voting, where voters of the same ethnicity as the candidate feel inspired to vote for them (Besco 2020). Or perhaps minority voters do not respond differently to co-ethnic candidates, and the only difference in votes they receive is due to something else such as party or ideology. To test this, the following hypotheses are established:

H1: A larger minority population in an electoral district is associated with a higher vote share for minority candidates, holding incumbency, number of candidates, district competitiveness, province, and the interaction between year and party constant.

H2: A larger minority population in an electoral district is associated with no difference in the vote share for minority candidates, holding incumbency, number of candidates, district competitiveness, province, and the interaction between year and party constant.

The third hypothesis is that when minority candidates run in an electoral district, this will inspire more minority candidates to run in the next election via “role model” effects. This effect has been elucidated by Ie et al. (2025), who explain findings from the literature that co-ethnic identities can increase political office-seeking through the effects of role models who have achieved political success in the past, or through the indication of an environment receptive to

minority candidates. To test whether such an effect exists across the federal election years of 2004 - 2021, this paper sets up a null and alternative hypothesis:

H3: A greater number of minority candidates will choose to run in districts that had co-ethnic minority candidates in the past, holding minority population share, incumbency, number of candidates, district competitiveness, province, and the interaction between year and party constant.

H4: The number of past co-ethnic minority candidates has no effect on whether minority candidates choose to run, holding minority population share, incumbency, number of candidates, district competitiveness, province, and the interaction between year and party constant.

Methods

Using census data gathered from Elections Canada, as well as an aggregated dataset of federal electoral candidates from 2004-2021, this paper will examine whether minority population share affects electoral success for minority candidates. It will first provide descriptive statistics about the demographics of minorities and minority Members of Parliament in Canada, before creating specific visualizations and a regression model that interacts year and party, to isolate the variation of party popularity fluctuations. Finally, this paper will test Ie et al.'s (2025) finding that candidates prefer to run in ridings with a greater number of candidates from their ethnic background.

This paper will examine changes in the dependent variable (minority candidates' share of votes) alongside changes in the independent variable (first, minority population share, then a lagged variable measuring the share of in-group candidates in the last election). This lagged variable was created by measuring the percentage of candidates in the prior election that match a current candidate's ethnicity (such as 25% of candidates in 2015 matching a South Asian candidate's ethnicity in 2019). Control variables used in the multiple regression models will be discussed in detail in the regression section.

Finally, due to the lack of recent census data for the 2025 federal election, and the altered electoral boundaries following the 2023 Representation Order, this analysis will include only the election years between 2004-2021. Excluding 2025 was a deliberate choice to avoid biased and outdated census data dating back to 2021, which still employed the older electoral districts.

Results

Results I - Descriptive Statistics

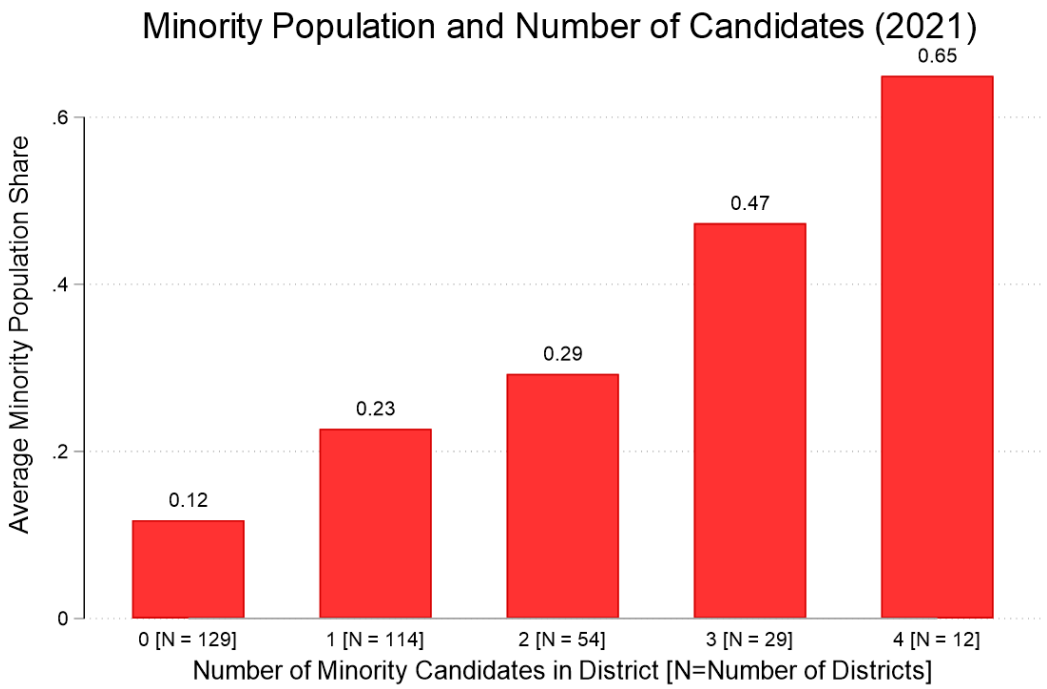
Ethnicity	Total Population Share, 2021	Representation in the House of Commons, 2021
White	69.8%	81%
Black	4.2%	2.36%
Arab	1.9%	1.77%
Chinese	4.5%	1.77%
Filipino	2.5%	0.29%
Indigenous	4.8%	2.9%
Japanese	0.27%	0%
Korean	0.57%	0%
Latin American	1.58%	0.59%
South Asian	6.5%	6.8%
Southeast Asian	1%	0.029%
West Asian	0.94%	0.59%
Total Minority (excl. white)	28.76%	16.57%

It is unsurprising that higher minority population shares are correlated with higher numbers of minority candidates in a district, for two reasons. First, minority candidates may seek to represent their community within their own riding, and a higher population level is more likely

to lead to politically motivated individuals who seek office. Second, parties may strategically run minority candidates in these ridings in order to capture greater shares of the minority vote, perhaps knowing that ethnic affinity voting effects exist (Besco 2020).

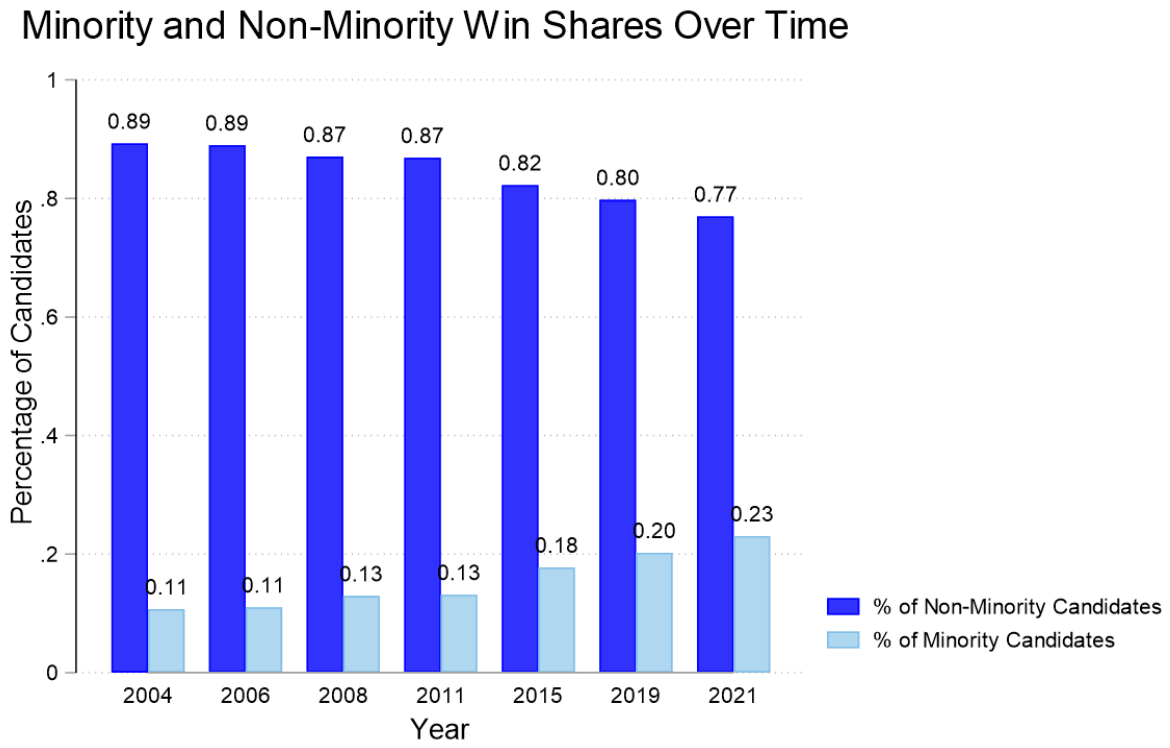
Results II - Visualizations

Firstly, to visualize the relationship between district demographics and the number of minority candidates that run, a bar graph was created, directly replicating the one in Ie et al.'s paper.

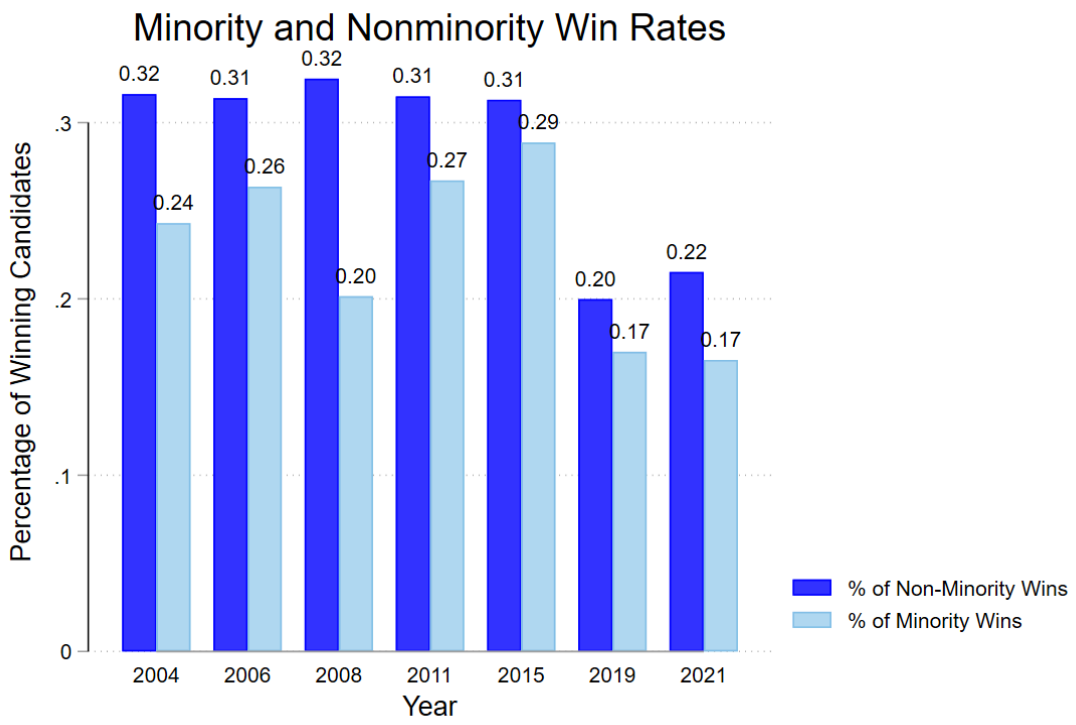


This bar graph shows for the districts with different numbers of minority candidates, what was the average minority population share? Districts with 0 minority candidates in 2021 had the lowest minority population share of 12%, whereas districts with 5 minority candidates had the higher minority population of 65%. There appears to be a direct increase in minority candidates with higher minority population shares. Whether it is a deliberate strategy by the party to run

minority candidates in minority-rich districts, or occurs via candidate self-selection due to role model effects, or is due to other causes will be examined in the next section.



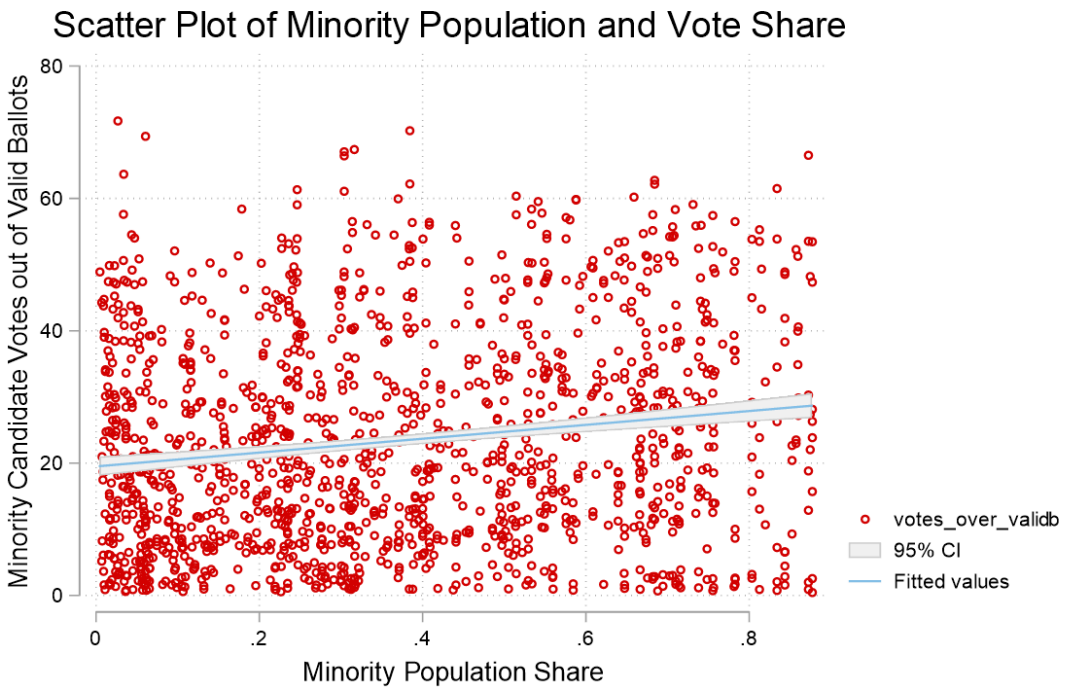
Second, to visualize the proportion of electoral winners that were minorities versus white candidates, a bar graph was created comparing the two groups across election years. The proportion of minority winners has steadily increased from 11% in 2004 to 23% in 2021. This indicates that the House of Commons has gradually become more diverse over time, however as the table above demonstrated, nearly all minority groups were still underrepresented in 2021. Next, a graph showing the proportion of minority candidates who end up winning, compared to white candidates who win, is created.



This bar graph depicts the share of minority winners out of the total minority candidates running across election years (light blue), and the non-minority winners out of total non-minority candidates (dark blue). It is interesting to note that although the vast majority of candidates who run do not end up winning due to Canada's first-past-the-post electoral system, comparing win rates directly does reveal a discrepancy between minority and white win rates. The share of minority winners out of total minority candidates was 17% in 2021 compared to 22% of all white candidates being winners. Could this gap possibly be related to the demographics of the particular ridings that minority candidates run in? This paper will examine whether a relationship exists between minority win rates and the ethnic makeup of electoral districts.

While a previous graph established than more minority candidates are run in high-minority ridings, it is impossible to know the counterfactual (if candidates would perform worse in ridings with a low minority population, seeing as either parties may select minority

candidates to run in those districts, or candidates may self-select to run in high-minority ridings). This is why this paper will attempt to examine whether riding demographics or role model effects have a greater impact on the electoral outcomes of minority candidates, using a multiple regression model.



This scatter plot shows the relationship between the minority population across districts and the share of votes for minority candidates. Visually, there is clearly an extremely weak linear relationship in the data, as the points are incredibly scattered and the variables do not appear to increase or decrease with each other. This is reinforced by a weak positive correlation of 0.1641, indicating a weak relationship. In the next section, this paper will run a regression model examining the relationship between riding demographics and electoral outcomes.

Results III - Regression

Could the win rates of minority candidates be influenced by the demographics of the ridings they run in, even if they are strategically run there by their party? To examine whether a

riding with a greater minority population share results in greater minority candidate success, a first regression model will be run. This model regresses the number of votes over valid ballots cast (vote share) for minority candidates, on the minority population share. A variety of control variables are used to avoid omitted variable bias, whereby an external factor is both correlated with the independent variable, and causes the outcome.

The first control used is the particular riding, in order to control for variation across different districts (such as the particular context of ethnic attitudes within one riding). The choice to include the riding variable as a control was informed by Black and Erickson (2006), who controlled for constituency variables to determine minority candidate vote share. The second control variable used was the incumbency of the candidate, which has greater effects on vote share for minority candidates than non-minority ones (Black and Erickson 2006, 544). Third, a control for the number of candidates in a district was added, since mathematically, as the number of candidates increases, vote share will automatically decrease per candidate.

The fourth control added was for district competitiveness, in order to absorb variation stemming from certain seats being more competitive than others. In her paper *Who You Know*, Tolley controls for riding competitiveness in order to estimate the effect of a local party president's race on minority candidate emergence (Tolley 2019, 36). A fifth control is an interacted control between year, and party, to account for variation stemming from certain years where parties perform worse or better. And finally, similar to Tolley (2019), a control for province was added. Another strong control would have been individual candidate experience and education level, however this data was unfortunately unavailable in the current dataset.

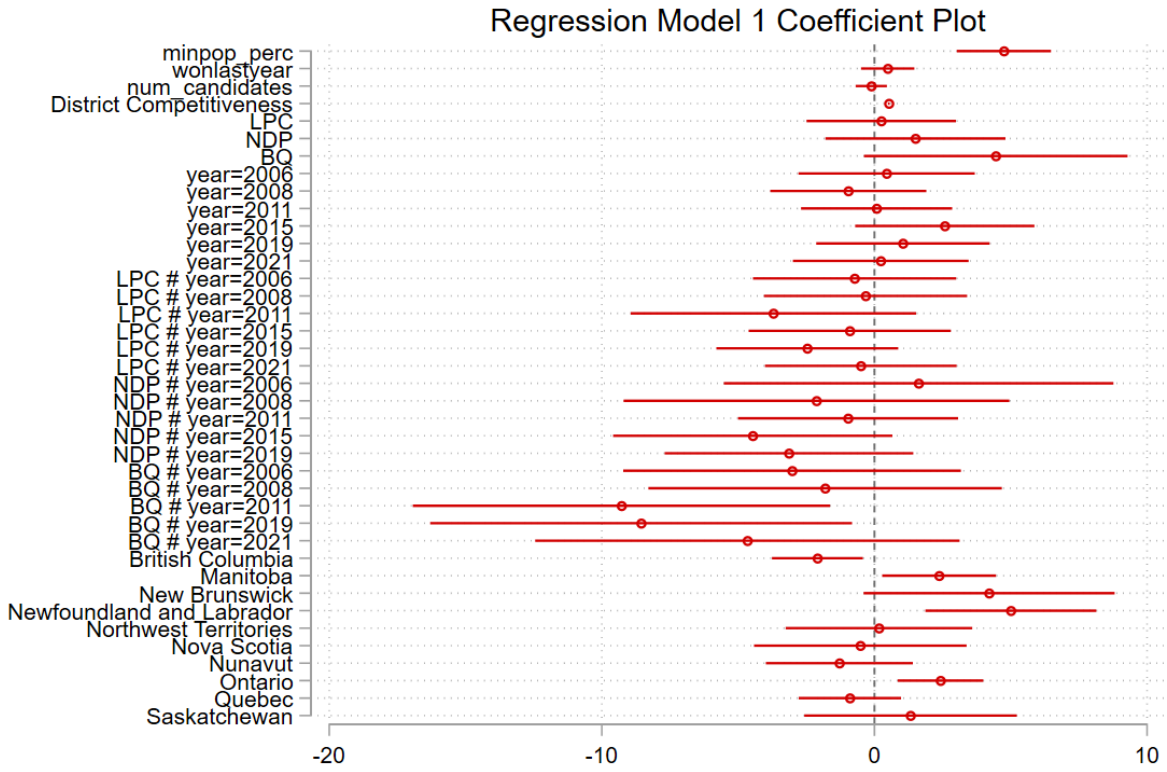
Regression Model 1 Results

minority_vote_~e	Coef.	Std. Err.	t	P>|t|	[95% Conf. Interval]	
minpop_perc	4.748383	.8781921	5.41	0.000	3.01895	6.477816
wonlastyear	.4865893	.4971103	0.98	0.329	-.4923752	1.465554
num_candidates	-.1145863	.2906564	-0.39	0.694	-.6869791	.4578065
margin_of_win	.5298423	.0162725	32.56	0.000	.4977967	.5618879
party						
LPC	.2506928	1.391236	0.18	0.857	-2.489083	2.990468
NDP	1.503121	1.678292	0.90	0.371	-1.801958	4.8082
BQ	4.451122	2.455601	1.81	0.071	-.3847186	9.286962
year						
2006	.4476308	1.642619	0.27	0.785	-2.787196	3.682458
2008	-.9582151	1.452763	-0.66	0.510	-3.819157	1.902726
2011	.0781184	1.408704	0.06	0.956	-2.696058	2.852295
2015	2.579341	1.670708	1.54	0.124	-.710802	5.869485
2019	1.04387	1.613425	0.65	0.518	-2.133466	4.221205
2021	.2314652	1.63622	0.14	0.888	-2.990759	3.45369
party#year						
LPC#2006	-.7287401	1.893709	-0.38	0.701	-4.458041	3.00056
LPC#2008	-.3248141	1.891844	-0.17	0.864	-4.050443	3.400814
LPC#2011	-3.708254	2.65954	-1.39	0.164	-8.945714	1.529206
LPC#2015	-.9059047	1.88355	-0.48	0.631	-4.615199	2.80339
LPC#2019	-2.465119	1.694341	-1.45	0.147	-5.801802	.8715641
LPC#2021	-.4986882	1.785271	-0.28	0.780	-4.014442	3.017065
NDP#2004	0	(empty)				
NDP#2006	1.620203	3.627901	0.45	0.656	-5.524261	8.764666
NDP#2008	-2.1277	3.593474	-0.59	0.554	-9.204368	4.948967
NDP#2011	-.9685445	2.049389	-0.47	0.637	-5.004428	3.067339
NDP#2015	-4.464681	2.60195	-1.72	0.087	-9.588729	.6593679
NDP#2019	-3.136866	2.315824	-1.35	0.177	-7.697443	1.423711
NDP#2021	0	(omitted)				
BQ#2006	-3.019739	3.145321	-0.96	0.338	-9.213852	3.174375
BQ#2008	-1.81073	3.292189	-0.55	0.583	-8.294073	4.672613
BQ#2011	-9.278976	3.886686	-2.39	0.018	-16.93307	-1.624885
BQ#2015	0	(empty)				
BQ#2019	-8.558324	3.929582	-2.18	0.030	-16.29689	-.8197573
BQ#2021	-4.65974	3.953416	-1.18	0.240	-12.44524	3.125765
province						
British Columbia	-2.091973	.8474345	-2.47	0.014	-3.760834	-.4231107
Manitoba	2.372582	1.060398	2.24	0.026	.2843285	4.460836
New Brunswick	4.205457	2.338838	1.80	0.073	-.4004423	8.811356
Newfoundland ..	5.003719	1.592977	3.14	0.002	1.866652	8.140785
Northwest Ter..	.1657597	1.737634	0.10	0.924	-3.256181	3.5877

Nova Scotia	-.5178665	1.979181	-0.26	0.794	-4.415488	3.379755
Nunavut	-1.286108	1.369561	-0.94	0.349	-3.983198	1.410983
Ontario	2.422298	.7975271	3.04	0.003	.8517189	3.992876
Quebec	-.9020705	.9538497	-0.95	0.345	-2.780497	.9763557
Saskatchewan	1.321623	1.979654	0.67	0.505	-2.57693	5.220177
_cons	35.12413	1.589052	22.10	0.000	31.9948	38.25347

The findings of the first OLS regression model appear to confirm H1: that as minority population share increases, the number of minority candidates will increase, controlling for incumbency, number of candidates, district competitiveness, year, party, and province. The coefficient for minority population percentage is statistically significant, with a p-value of nearly 0 (rounded down by Stata). To interpret the coefficient, a one percentage point increase in minority population share is correlated with a 4.75 percentage point increase in the vote share for a minority candidate, when incumbency, number of candidates, district competitiveness, province, and the interaction between year and party are held constant. In other words, there does indeed appear to be a positive association between minority population and votes won by a minority candidate, when isolating the impact of other factors. This suggests a strong positive relationship.

Another interesting result revealed by this regression is that a 1 percentage point increase in the win margin is associated with a 0.53 percentage point increase in a minority candidate's vote share. This means that in less competitive ridings where the margin of victory is wider (indicating a less tight competition), minority candidates receive slightly more votes. After the regression, a coefficient plot was created to visualize the statistical significance of the variables.



This plot visually shows the coefficients and their 95% confidence intervals of the first regression model. It is clear that minority population share is statistically significant, as well as district competitiveness. To specifically test the finding of Ie et al (2025) that candidates prefer to run in ridings with a greater share of candidates belonging to the same ethnic group, a second regression model was run, regressing the number of minority candidates on the lagged number of minority candidates in the prior election, and controlling for minority population share, incumbency, number of candidates, district competitiveness, year, party, and province.

Regression Model 2 Results

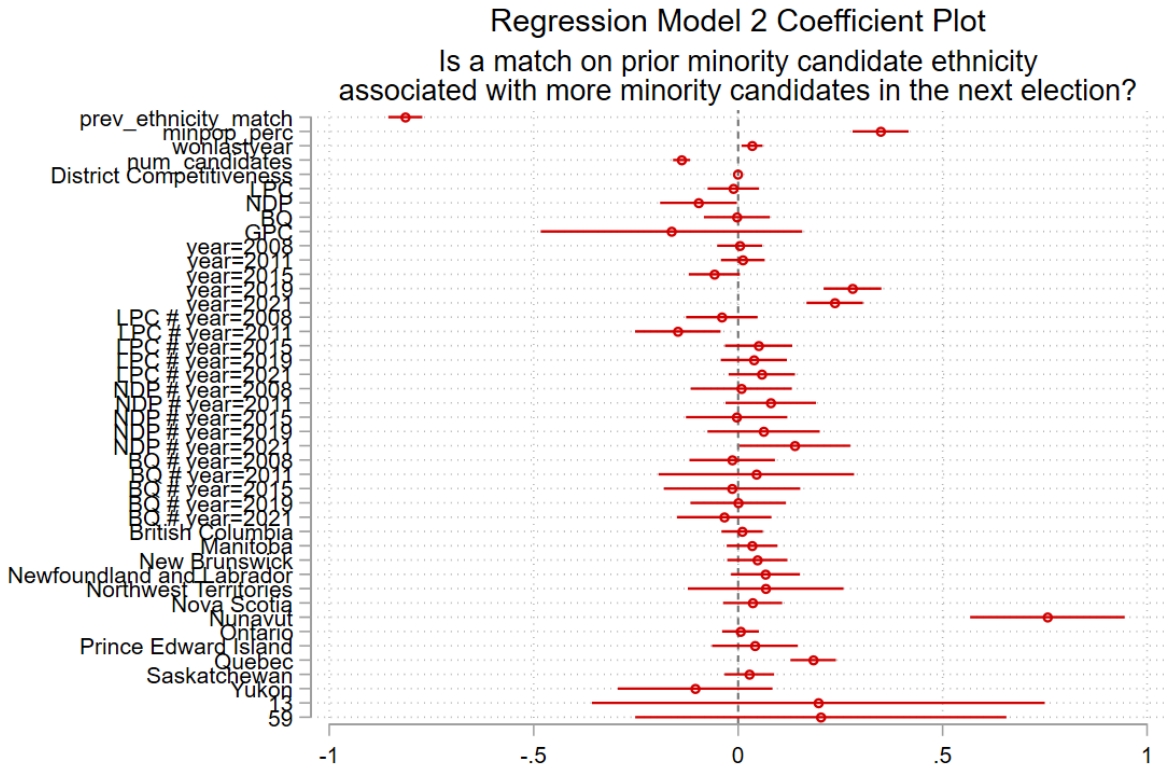
minority_candi~e	Coef.	Std. Err.	t	P>|t|	[95% Conf. Interval]	
prev_ethnicity~h	-.8141658	.0211653	-38.47	0.000	-.8556756	-.7726559
minpop_perc	.3483301	.0348714	9.99	0.000	.2799396	.4167205
wonlastyear	.0339542	.0130214	2.61	0.009	.0084164	.059492
num_candidates	-.1384217	.0105442	-13.13	0.000	-.1591013	-.1177422
margin_of_win	-.0009605	.0003985	-2.41	0.016	-.0017421	-.0001789

party						
LPC	-.0118104	.032092	-0.37	0.713	-.0747498	.051129
NDP	-.0969825	.047862	-2.03	0.043	-.1908503	-.0031148
BQ	-.0031898	.0410231	-0.08	0.938	-.0836451	.0772655
GPC	-.1630907	.1630238	-1.00	0.317	-.482816	.1566345
year						
2008	.0039697	.0281109	0.14	0.888	-.0511619	.0591012
2011	.0113108	.0272256	0.42	0.678	-.0420845	.064706
2015	-.0582579	.031854	-1.83	0.068	-.1207306	.0042149
2019	.2796559	.0360342	7.76	0.000	.208985	.3503269
2021	.2361885	.0351239	6.72	0.000	.1673029	.3050741
party#year						
LPC#2008	-.0399586	.0445694	-0.90	0.370	-.127369	.0474517
LPC#2011	-.1476181	.0533324	-2.77	0.006	-.2522146	-.0430217
LPC#2015	.0501172	.0419617	1.19	0.232	-.0321789	.1324134
LPC#2019	.0384287	.0411579	0.93	0.351	-.042291	.1191483
LPC#2021	.0577759	.0413502	1.40	0.163	-.023321	.1388728
NDP#2008	.0077706	.0629398	0.12	0.902	-.115668	.1312093
NDP#2011	.0796308	.0564165	1.41	0.158	-.0310142	.1902758
NDP#2015	-.0037359	.0631587	-0.06	0.953	-.127604	.1201322
NDP#2019	.0622168	.0699113	0.89	0.374	-.0748945	.199328
NDP#2021	.1384053	.069231	2.00	0.046	.0026282	.2741824
BQ#2008	-.0145853	.0532826	-0.27	0.784	-.1190841	.0899134
BQ#2011	.0445242	.1218417	0.37	0.715	-.194434	.2834825
BQ#2015	-.014999	.0849459	-0.18	0.860	-.1815964	.1515985
BQ#2019	.0001242	.0594623	0.00	0.998	-.1164944	.1167429
BQ#2021	-.0341614	.0589705	-0.58	0.562	-.1498154	.0814927
GPC#2006	0	(empty)				
GPC#2008	0	(empty)				
GPC#2011	0	(empty)				
GPC#2015	0	(empty)				
GPC#2019	0	(omitted)				
GPC#2021	0	(omitted)				
province						
British Colum..	.0097674	.0258185	0.38	0.705	-.0408683	.0604032
Manitoba	.0339607	.0315158	1.08	0.281	-.0278486	.09577
New Brunswick	.0469148	.0375295	1.25	0.211	-.0266887	.1205183
Newfoundland ..	.0667074	.0429395	1.55	0.120	-.0175063	.1509212
Northwest Ter..	.0673031	.0970456	0.69	0.488	-.1230245	.2576306
Nova Scotia	.0354096	.0368203	0.96	0.336	-.0368031	.1076223
Nunavut	.7564884	.0963678	7.85	0.000	.56749	.9454869
Ontario	.0057673	.0229298	0.25	0.801	-.039203	.0507376
Prince Edward..	.0409741	.0534151	0.77	0.443	-.0637846	.1457328
Quebec	.1835716	.0282233	6.50	0.000	.1282195	.2389237
Saskatchewan	.0273284	.0308021	0.89	0.375	-.0330813	.0877381

Yukon	-.105083	.0964135	-1.09	0.276	-.294171	.0840049
13	.1961946	.2822922	0.70	0.487	-.3574421	.7498313
59	.2021092	.2313978	0.87	0.383	-.2517124	.6559308
_cons	1.161467	.0534932	21.71	0.000	1.056555	1.266379

Surprisingly, the results of this regression contradict H3: that a higher number of co-ethnic minority candidates in the prior election would inspire an increased number of minority candidates to run in the following election. The coefficient for the lagged variable measuring in-group candidate match level is statistically significant (this independent variable measures if a black candidate runs in 2021, it was hypothesized that witnessing three black candidates out of five in the same riding in the 2019 election would have a greater impact on their choice to run than witnessing just one black candidate out of five in the prior election). Because the coefficient is -0.81, this means a 1 percentage point increase in the prior ethnicity match is associated with 0.81 less minority candidates in the next election, holding constant minority population share, incumbency, number of candidates, district competitiveness, province, and the interaction between year and party.

There may perhaps be some spuriousness in this result as it was established that the share of minority candidates is increasing over time, and that minorities perform better in minority-dense ridings, which would point toward minority candidates increasing as representation grows. It may be beneficial to re-examine this regression with only winning candidates, such that as minority representation in the House of Commons grows, minority candidates may feel more inclined to run.



This second coefficient plot highlights how the percentage ethnicity match of candidates in the last election actually decreases the number of minority candidates in the next election, and is statistically significant. Minority population share is also significant, and a one percentage point increase in minority population share is associated with a 0.35 percentage point increase in minority candidates running in the election.

Conclusion

In conclusion, this paper set out to test two main hypotheses: first that electoral districts with higher minority population shares tend to have higher vote shares for minority candidates, and second that role model effects lead increased numbers of minority candidates to run in an election if they witnessed same-ethnicity candidates in the prior election. The results of the first multiple regression model seem to confirm that a positive correlation exists between larger minority populations and increased vote shares for minority candidates. However it is impossible

to know for certain whether this is due to parties choosing to run minority candidates in high-minority ridings out of a belief that they will perform better there, or due to self-selection by candidates wanting to run in a heavily co-ethnic riding, or a different effect entirely. Future research should continue to explore this relationship, while also isolating the effects of career experience and education level of individual candidates to see if individual accomplishments by minority candidates affect their electoral success.

This relationship is important to examine due to Canada's increasingly diverse demography, and the clear lack of representation for ethnic and racial minorities in politics. It is possible that minority candidates vote for in-group candidates out of affinity effects, with Besco (2020) finding that minority voters, in particular Chinese and South Asian voters, tend to have the highest support for candidates of the same ethnicity. The exact mechanism by which high-minority ridings are associated with higher minority vote shares is important to understand, especially if it is a causal relationship where ethnic community support is key in acquiring more votes. This would mean that race and ethnicity is an important way that ethnic communities in Canada wish to be represented, and actively drive their voting decisions. Whether ethnic voting is more important than party or ideology should be further studied in the future.

This paper failed to disconfirm the second null hypothesis (that minority candidates will not inspire more co-ethnic minority candidates in the following election). In fact, the presence of same-ethnicity minority candidates in the prior election is actually associated with decreased numbers of minority candidates in the present election. This may be due to spuriousness from one of the control variables skewing the true relationship between the lagged minority candidate variable, and the present minority candidate variable. Future research should attempt to examine this relationship by carefully selecting control variables to ensure minimal spuriousness. This

second relationship is crucial to re-examine due to the possibility that greater minority representation in elections inspiring further generations to participate in politics. As newcomers integrate into Canadian society, it is important for there to exist examples of co-ethnic politicians in power, as this is the backbone of a representative democracy that works for the people.

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